ideals to be pursued thereafter. India, too, had this ideal of a centralized state, set forth in great detail in Kautilya's *Arthashastra* . The Mauryan empire of Chandragupta and Ashoka extended over most of the Indian geography. But unlike in China, this idea did not evolve into an enduring political category. A more traditional feudal structure with networks of distributed power became the norm, with the authority of the centre waxing and waning in response to external and internal factors.

The role played by a unified Chinese script in enabling relative uniformity in governance structures cannot be overemphasized.

In addition, the vast accumulation of documented history became a powerful source of political legitimization and narrative building in the service of ruling dispensations in China across the ages. There is nothing comparable with respect to India until after the first millennium and the advent of Islam. Furthermore, during the second millennium in India, a number of regional languages and scripts evolved into complex linguistic entities and this gave rise to a rich store of local histories.

The peculiarity of the Chinese language and its long evolution have also influenced Chinese political behaviour. It has been pointed out how tonal changes lead to complete changes in meaning even though the word is pronounced in the same way. (See 'A Note on the Chinese Script' in the Appendix) This creates immense opportunities for deliberate ambiguity, and this ambiguity is used widely in political discourse, particularly if explicit criticism or opposition to those in authority may entail risk. During the Tiananmen protests of 1989, the students gathered at the square expressed their frustration with the top leader of the time, Deng Xiaoping, by breaking small bottles on the ground, 'Xiaoping' being a homophone for 'small bottles'. The word for marijuana in Chinese is pronounced 'Da Ma'. However, in Chinese social media these two characters for marijuana are often used for Xi Jinping and his wife, Peng Liyuan. The two are affectionately referred to as 'Xi Dada' and 'Peng Mama'. Da Ma, as spelt for 'marijuana', then becomes an artful way of referring to them and escaping the censors until they catch on, which they usually do. But it is also true that words made up of two characters together enable very fine